

NO ENTRY A US Border Patrol agent leads a group of Indian immigrants from the US-Mexico border in Arizona, Dec. 8, 2023

these immigrants are paid $10-12 (Rs 830 to Rs 1,000) per hour or less, and no overtime charges. They work odd hours, through weekends and keep to their place of work for fear of being apprehended. Employers keep their passports, making them open-air prisoners. Despite these ordeals, "there is an inexplicable craze in these villages for a life in the US, which is unfortunately only spreading," says Kharat.

The life-threatening risks of being trafficked through countries and encounters through forests, drug cartels and wildlife, with the dangers of dodging law enforcers, have turned into a medal of sorts that these families back home recount to their children as modern-day parables of valour. No surprise then that they grow up romanticising these adventures and dream of becoming heroes by entering the US as illegal immigrants.

At the heart of this blind craze are several deep-rooted social evils that have plagued the villages of Gandhinagar, Mehsana and Anand districts for generations now. The most striking being the case of the missing daughters. The desire for a son has meant female foeticide. Gujarat has the third-lowest sex ratio at birth in the country with 909 girls per 1,000 boys, lower than the national average of 940. "Patel boys do not find brides in their community. Many marry tribal girls, which means a difficult cultural adjustment for the family as well as the girl, and such unions struggle. Patel girls are at a premium, who prefer boys settled in the US so that they can have a comfortable life, independent of in-laws," says Rannaben.

BY HOOK OR BY CROOK

Pandian says there are mainly two ways illegal immigration takes place. First, visa agents connive with foreign educational institutions for fake admission offers and get a genuine visa for the intended destination. Second, they take the travellers to Dubai with a valid visa. For the onward journey, they are shown as part of a cultural troupe or tourists. Agents from Delhi, Haryana and Gujarat control this nexus through local contacts at every stopover.

"Earlier, they used to fly directly to Mexico and escape before immigration or during transit from the airport, but that was a serious security hazard that seems to have been fixed by the country," says Pandian. "Now, they use multiple country stopovers, with the average cost ranging between Rs 50 lakh and Rs 80 lakh. The higher end of the package includes food packets and lawyer fees for asylum. The USCBP treats them as victims of human trafficking." After a headline-hitting event, the agents slow down for a while, but restart soon enough. "We are focusing on cracking the local agent network, the first point of contact for the victims," says Pandian. "We also need more data from other stakeholders like embassies, travel agents, the Intelligence Bureau, International Air Transport Association."

Operations in plain sight are par for the course on the streets of Mehsana city and its surrounding villages. A 35-year-old agent spills the beans on several modes of transit. "Earlier, we used to fly directly to Mexico, but the administration there has become greedy. They track our travellers and smoke them out. Oiling their greedy machinery was financially untenable," he says. "Now, we fly into Mexico from different countries to avoid the attention of their immigration officers. However, we know it is a matter of time before this track gets busted, but we will cross that bridge when we come to it."

Of late, the long-winding legal ways to become a US green-card holder through investment or skilled work permits are losing popularity in India. Ahmedabad-based veteran visa consultant Lalit Advani, who specialises in EB5 (employment-based, fifth preference) visas that grant permanent resident status, attributes the massive rise in illegal immigration to one extremely significant change that is no longer illegal. "You get an EB5 green card after spending nearly a million dollars and a few years in the queue," he says. "That you can actually walk across the border in the US and get a social security number and facilities that permanent residents get plus a work permit for a fraction of that amount negates the basis of visa processes for a legal work permit."

Wisened by years of travel between India and the US, Babubhai claims that the governments of both countries are aware of the goings-on and exactly how to curb it, but want it to continue. "Why are you wasting your time on the issue? There are no victims here," he says. Only an intricate combination of ambition and adversity. ■